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Hong Kong's non-local undergraduate recruitment: Policies, institutional practices and student perspectives

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Abstract

Beneath the Hong Kong government's enthusiasm for recruiting non-local undergraduates—including students from the Chinese Mainland and other international regions—lies a longstanding gap in understanding the core meanings and drivers shaping the territory's expanding focus on inward international student mobility (ISM). This study extends Bourdieu's capital framework beyond its traditional individual-centred application to explore how the dynamics of economic, cultural, social and symbolic capital operate across macro (policy), meso (institutional) and micro (student) levels within Hong Kong's recruitment strategies. Drawing on a mixed-methods dataset—including policy documents, perspectives from university managers and both questionnaire surveys and semi-structured interviews with non-local undergraduates—the research identifies three key cross-level themes: (1) While non-local students are universally regarded as vital to higher education internationalisation and the accumulation of symbolic capital, Hong Kong's efforts to leverage its role as a 'super-connector' with the Chinese Mainland to attract students beyond the Greater China region remain fragmented and ineffective; (2) Despite broad intentions to foster (inter)cultural capital—primarily for local students' benefit—institutions' capacities to address inwardly mobile students' diverse needs remain underdeveloped, creating misalignments between rhetoric and practice; and (3) Although economic capital gains from non-local undergraduate

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recruitment are increasingly crucial for institutions facing funding pressures, these benefits are downplayed within policy discourse. These findings highlight systemic inconsistencies in how inward ISM is understood and operationalised across different levels, offering critical insights for refining the 'Study in Hong Kong' branding to better align policy aspirations, institutional practices and student priorities.

KEYWORDS

capital, Hong Kong, inward international student mobility (ISM), non-local undergraduate students

Key insights

What is the main issue that the paper addresses?

This paper extends Bourdieu's capital framework beyond its traditional focus on individuals. It explores how economic, cultural, social and symbolic capital operate across macro, meso and micro levels within Hong Kong's strategies for recruiting non-local undergraduates.

What are the main insights that the paper provides?

This paper highlights systemic inconsistencies in how inward international student mobility (ISM) is understood and implemented across various levels. It provides valuable insights for refining the 'Study in Hong Kong' branding to better align policy goals, institutional practices and student priorities.

INTRODUCTION

While the prevailing narrative in international student mobility (ISM) scholarship often emphasises South-to-North flows and frames these movements within a neoliberal paradigm, this 'neoliberal reductionism'—which primarily regards international education as a strategic tool for revenue generation—may, whether intentionally or unintentionally, obscure other underlying motivations (de Wit, 2020; Lomer, 2018; Yang, 2022). Such motivations encompass the expansive aspirations of increasingly ambitious jurisdictions seeking to establish themselves as global or regional higher education hubs: enhancing prestige, projecting soft power and advancing regional development objectives, among others (Knight, 2018). Recognising and understanding these diverse supply-side rationales are essential for developing an important perspective on the complex dynamics shaping international higher education today. Meanwhile, a purely supply-side analysis of inward ISM risks neglecting the perspectives and experiences of international students themselves, who move to a new jurisdiction to pursue higher education. Their motives—such as obtaining internationally recognised academic qualifications (Brooks & Waters, 2011) and cultivating a cosmopolitan

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outlook (Rizvi & Choo, 2020)—may align with or diverge from the benefits emphasised by the receiving contexts. These disjunctions warrant closer examination.

Addressing these gaps necessitates a cross-level analytical approach that integrates macro (policy and systemic), meso (institutional) and micro (individual student) dynamics. ISM is not merely a product of top-down policies or bottom-up individual choices but emerges from the interaction of these layers: policies set strategic directions that institutions interpret and enact, which in turn shape the opportunities and constraints faced by students—whose experiences and agency may, in turn, influence institutional practices or policy priorities. However, much existing scholarship remains siloed within the three levels of analysis: macro-level analyses often narrowly focused on state or market logic, meso-level studies concentrate solely on institutional strategies and micro-level research prioritise individual narratives without sufficient connection to overarching structural forces. This fragmentation limits our understanding of how competing rationales—such as symbolic capital accumulation, cultural exchange or economic imperatives—are negotiated across different levels, and why disjunctions arise between policy ambitions, institutional realities and student experiences.

Against this backdrop, Hong Kong provides a compelling case study. As a jurisdiction actively positioning itself as a higher education hub (Knight, 2013, 2018; Oleksiyenko et al., 2021; Pan, 2021), its government and universities have demonstrated sustained enthusiasm for recruiting non-local undergraduates—comprising both students from the Chinese Mainland and from other international regions (Lee, 2024, 2025). Yet, beneath this enthusiasm lies a notable gap: a lack of nuanced understanding of the meanings, drivers and contradictions underpinning Hong Kong's growing focus on inward student mobility. Therefore, this study aims to address the following three research questions: (1) What are the motivations for enhancing inward ISM in Hong Kong? (2) How do institutional strategies align with or diverge from policy objectives? and (3) To what extent do the experiences and priorities of non-local students reflect the objectives of policymakers and higher education institutions?

This study seeks to address these questions by advancing ISM research through a multi-level application of Bourdieu's (1986) capital framework, moving beyond its traditional focus on individuals to incorporate macro, meso and micro perspectives. By analysing data from a diverse range of sources—including policy documents, questionnaires and interviews with university managers and non-local undergraduates—this research explores the complex interplay among stakeholders shaping inward ISM in Hong Kong. It investigates how convergences and divergences in interpretations of mobility manifest—from the symbolic capital associated with internationalisation to the (inter)cultural capital purportedly fostered by diverse student populations—and examines the often-overlooked economic dimensions of recruiting non-local undergraduates, which reveal cross-level contradictions. In doing so, this research aims to provide a more holistic understanding of inward ISM in Hong Kong, offering insights into how higher education hubs might better align their strategies with the realities of student experiences and broader societal goals.

INWARD ISM IN HONG KONG: POLICY FRAMEWORKS AND DEVELOPMENT TRENDS

Over the past two decades, the recruitment of non-local students has been a central strategy for the Hong Kong Special Administrative Region (HKSAR) government to establish the city as a regional and global higher education hub. The term ‘non-local’ encompasses both students from the Chinese Mainland and those from other backgrounds. As early as 2004, Tung Chee-hwa, the first Chief Executive of the HKSAR, announced plans to develop

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Hong Kong's higher education sector into a regional hub (University Grants Committee [UGC], 2004). By 2023, this ambition had evolved into positioning Hong Kong as a 'global hub'. In his 2024 and 2025 Policy Addresses, the current Chief Executive, John Lee Ka-chiu, outlined initiatives to promote the 'Study in Hong Kong' brand on a worldwide scale (Lee, 2024, 2025).

The brand emphasises five key attractions for prospective students: 'world-class institutions and programmes', 'government and private scholarships', 'a blend of Eastern and Western cultures', 'a gateway to the Chinese Mainland' and 'a modern, dynamic city'. These five pillars align with existing literature on non-local students, particularly regarding their pre-admission motivations for studying in Hong Kong, and macro-level recruitment policies, including quotas for non-local students (Bodycott & Lai, 2012; Li & Bray, 2007; Ng, 2012). Such studies highlight Hong Kong's appeal due to its strong economic and sociocultural environment, close business and cultural ties with the Chinese Mainland, prestigious universities and comparatively affordable tuition fees (Mok et al., 2021).

The expansion of non-local student quotas—from 4% in 2004–05 to 10% in 2005–06, 20% in 2008–09, 40% in 2024–25 and ultimately 50% in 2026–27—reflects the growing enrolment of non-local students in Hong Kong (Lee, 2025). Data from the UGC (2025) indicate that the non-local undergraduate student population peaked at 17,161 in 2024/25, representing 23.2% of the total undergraduate enrolment of 74,082. This marks a substantial increase from just 4790 students (8.7%) in 2008/09. Approximately 72% (12,386) of these students originate from the Chinese Mainland, with the remainder from other Asian countries (4181) and regions worldwide (594).

Hong Kong's internationalisation agenda also encompasses the Immigration Arrangement for Non-local Graduates (IANG), introduced in 2008, which permits non-local students to apply for work in Hong Kong after graduating with a bachelor's degree or higher from local institutions. According to the Education Bureau (EDB), the scheme aims to attract non-local graduates to stay and thrive in the city, thereby bolstering the local workforce and alleviating labour shortages (Government of the HKSAR, 2022). The scheme allows non-local graduates from accredited higher education institutions to apply for a 12-month visa, extended to 24 months in 2022, with no requirement to secure employment at the time of application—an exception to Hong Kong's otherwise stringent work visa regulations (Lee, 2022). Additionally, from November 2024, the government temporarily exempted full-time non-local undergraduate students from restrictions on part-time work to enhance their practical experience and understanding of the local labour market, increasing their incentives to remain after graduation.

These policies are designed to expand the non-local student cohort and reduce entry barriers for non-local graduates seeking employment in Hong Kong. Collectively, they play a vital role in positioning Hong Kong as a higher education hub and cultivating global talent—essential for maintaining the city's competitive edge (Government of the HKSAR, 2025).

LITERATURE REVIEW: ISM RATIONALES, CAPITAL DYNAMICS AND THE NEED FOR CROSS-LEVEL ANALYSIS

Existing scholarship on ISM has identified a range of drivers shaping the internationalisation of higher education, with student mobility itself recognised as a central pillar (Altbach & Knight, 2007; de Wit, 2020; Rizvi & Choo, 2020). Dominant narratives, particularly in research centred on Global North destinations such as Australia, Canada, the United Kingdom and the United States, emphasise economic motives as primary: international student recruitment, framed through a neoliberal lens, is often positioned as a revenue-generating strategy driven by declining public funding for higher education and the shift from aid-led

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to trade-oriented approaches (Stein & De Andreotti, 2016). Beyond immediate financial gains, host nations also benefit from the influx of skilled talent to address labour market shortages—an imperative for ageing economies with shrinking domestic graduate pools (Baas, 2019)—while emerging destinations view inward mobility as a means to counteract brain drain and secure future workforce capacity (Bodycott, 2016).

Alongside economic imperatives, political rationales—such as soft power projection, diplomatic influence and the cultivation of transnational social coalitions and networks—are prominent in ISM scholarship (Kapfudzaruwa, 2025). Nye's (2004) concept of 'soft power', which describes a nation's ability to shape others' behaviour through cultural appeal, political values or foreign policy, provides a valuable framework for understanding how international education serves geopolitical objectives by fostering enduring social and political connections. Historically, ISM was overtly politicised—particularly during the Cold War—not only to promote ideological agendas but also to build cross-border social coalitions: networks of educated elites, scholars and future leaders united by shared educational experiences, which reinforced political alignment and collaborative ties. Today, this dynamic persists: China's emergence as a leading inbound ISM hub, for example, is attributed not only to economic interests but also to state-led efforts to strengthen diplomatic ties, project cultural influence and cultivate transnational networks of alumni and partners whose shared educational experiences in China promote long-term social and political collaboration (Wu, 2019).

Complementing these economic, political and social drivers, educational and cultural rationales continue to serve as enduring motivations. Bodycott (2016) characterises the development of domestic higher education and intercultural understanding as the 'crowning prize' of ISM, highlighting the value of international students in diversifying campus demographics, enriching cultural pluralism and fostering cross-cultural exchange—dynamics rooted in the cultural capital that these students bring (Oleksiyenko et al., 2021).

To unpack these multifaceted rationales, scholars have turned to Bourdieu's (1986) concept of capital, which conceptualises resources—economic, cultural, social and symbolic—that structure social relations and power dynamics. Traditionally applied to individual or household strategies, Bourdieusian theory in ISM research has shed light on how studying abroad functions as a transnational practice that reproduces or enhances personal and familial capital (Brooks & Waters, 2011; Mazzarol & Soutar, 2002). More recently, scholars have extended this framework to macro and meso levels: Yang (2022), for example, analysed flows of economic, human and symbolic capital across outbound and inbound student mobility in China, demonstrating how capital accumulation operates not only for individuals but also for nations and institutions.

This adapted framework offers a nuanced lens to redefine forms of capital within the context of inward ISM, integrating both systemic dynamics and individual motivations: Economic capital encompasses macro-level policies and institutional strategies aimed at generating revenue (e.g. through non-local tuition fees) and strengthening the knowledge economy (Stein & De Andreotti, 2016). At the individual level, it reflects students' calculations of financial returns such as perceived career earnings post-graduation. Cultural capital involves the development of valued dispositions—such as global perspectives and intercultural competence—embedded within policy discourses and institutional practices (Oleksiyenko et al., 2021). Additionally, students' personal aspirations to acquire culturally symbolic competencies—such as bilingual proficiency or familiarity with East–West cultural norms—that can enhance their social and professional mobility are equally important. Social capital pertains to the deliberate cultivation of cross-jurisdictional networks—such as joint educational partnerships—at the institutional level (Sin et al., 2021), as well as students' motivations to forge transnational social ties—such as peer networks, academic collaborations or alumni connections—that broaden their personal and professional horizons. Symbolic capital captures intangible assets such as global prestige, institutional standing and soft power—assets

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that nations and universities seek to accrue through internationalisation (Yang, 2022). For individual students, it manifests in the symbolic value of a Hong Kong qualification—perceived as globally recognised—and the social status associated with studying in an internationally renowned education hub.

However, a critical gap remains within ISM scholarship: the failure to examine how capital dynamics unfold through interconnected, cross-level interactions. Existing research tends to be fragmented along analytical silos: macro-level inquiries focus narrowly on state policy architectures or market logics (e.g. neoliberal revenue imperatives), often without considering how these influence on-the-ground institutional practices tied to capital accumulation; meso-level studies concentrate on university strategies—such as recruitment frameworks or student support models—without anchoring them within broader policy discourses that enable or constrain the cultivation of cultural, social or symbolic capital; and micro-level investigations prioritise individual student narratives, often decoupling them from the structural forces (e.g. funding mandates, policy priorities) that shape their pursuit of economic gains, transnational networks or globally recognised credentials (Gao et al., 2024).

This study directly addresses this lacuna by operationalising a cross-level Bourdieusian framework to analyse inward ISM in Hong Kong. Rather than treating analytical levels as discrete entities, it examines how economic, cultural, social and symbolic capital are constructed, contested and negotiated across macro (Hong Kong government policy), meso (university institutional strategy) and micro (non-local student experience) layers. By mapping these interconnected capital dynamics, the research illuminates the tensions, convergences and misalignments that shape Hong Kong's non-local undergraduate recruitment landscape. In doing so, it advances a more integrated, relational understanding of ISM—one that captures how structural imperatives at macro and meso levels and individual agency at micro level mutually influence capital-driven mobility. This approach offers valuable insights into the future of higher education internationalisation in regional hubs.

METHODOLOGY

A convergent parallel design within a mixed-methods approach was employed to collect and analyse quantitative and qualitative data concurrently, thereby fulfilling the research objectives (Creswell & Clark, 2017). Data were collected between March 2024 and September 2025 from a range of sources, including documentary analysis of policy documents, institutional materials and media coverage, to establish a foundational understanding of ISM policies and initiatives. In-depth interviews with university managers examined how capital-driven policy initiatives are interpreted and enacted at the institutional level. Additionally, a structured questionnaire and semi-structured interviews with non-local undergraduates across eight UGC-funded universities provided in-depth insights into their motivations, perceptions and post-arrival experiences. Collectively, these methods facilitated a layered analysis of the motivations behind securing valuable capital resources through inward ISM, and how these factors influence students' choices and experiences, offering a nuanced understanding of the complex dynamics shaping inward mobility in Hong Kong.

Data sources

The documentary data comprised Policy Addresses and their supplements, which outline official policy decisions, alongside reports from the UGC and the EDB—including submissions to the Legislative Council (LegCo) and correspondence with LegCo members. Additional sources included files from the LegCo Secretariat, especially those related to the

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Panel on Education and its Subcommittee on Promoting the Development of Hong Kong as an International Education Hub. Publicly available resources from the UGC website (such as FAQs) and the websites of eight UGC-funded universities were also examined. Media coverage from both local and international outlets—including *China Daily* and *University World News*—was included, along with content from the 'Study in Hong Kong' portal and primary data collected directly by the UGC and EDB. Particular focus was given to policy documents concerning inward ISM, especially from 2022 onwards, when the government increased investment in attracting non-local students. Earlier publicly available documents were also analysed to trace the evolution of key mandates that have shaped institutional practices and interpretations over time.

Complementing the document analysis, six staff members participated in online interviews conducted with prior informed consent. These informants held leadership roles related to non-local student recruitment or worked directly with non-local students on campus (Merriam, 2002). To maintain confidentiality, details such as institutional affiliations, gender and other identifying information were not disclosed. The interviews were conducted as one-on-one, semi-structured sessions, each lasting approximately 1 h and were audio-recorded. Discussions focused on institutional rationales and practices for recruiting non-local students, participants' roles and responsibilities in implementing government policies, and the challenges encountered in attracting and supporting these students. This method generated rich qualitative insights into the practical realities and strategic considerations of inward ISM from the perspective of university leadership.

To supplement these macro- and meso-level data, an online questionnaire survey was administered to 169 non-local undergraduates across the eight University Grants Committee (UGC)-funded universities in Hong Kong. In addition to demographic backgrounds, the primary aim was to explore the push and pull factors that influenced their decision to study in Hong Kong. The existing literature on push-pull factors was thoroughly reviewed (e.g. Altbach, 2004; Chen, 2017; Mazzarol & Soutar, 2002), and a pilot study was conducted to test and refine the questionnaire items prior to full deployment. Participants rated the importance of various push and pull factors influencing their study decisions using a 5-point Likert scale (1 = least important, 5 = most important). These factors were explicitly aligned with different forms of capital; for example, a university's ranking was considered an indicator of symbolic capital, and its significance was rated accordingly. Additionally, semi-structured individual and focus group interviews were conducted with 96 non-local undergraduates (comprising 65 from the Chinese Mainland and 31 international students across various years of study), either on university campuses or virtually. These sessions lasted between 45 min and 1.5 h and comprised two sets of questions: the first concerning the push and pull factors underpinning their educational choices (e.g. 'Why did you choose to study abroad?', 'What factors facilitated or hindered your decision to study in Hong Kong and at this specific institution/programme?'), and the second reflecting on their post-arrival experiences (e.g. 'What difficulties or challenges have you faced at university that may differ from your expectations before arriving?'). Prompts were used to encourage reflexivity in their decision-making processes.

Data analysis

Content analysis was utilised to examine the documentary data, focusing on three key dimensions (Atkinson & Coffey, 2004): first, the explicit information conveyed—such as policies, practices, strategies and perspectives of the HKSAR government regarding non-local undergraduate recruitment; second, the underlying values and assumptions embedded within the texts, as held by policymakers and institutions; and third, the arguments and debates

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articulated within or surrounding the documents. This approach aimed to address the first two research questions by unpacking how policies are constructed, justified and contested, with each document's meaning interpreted within its immediate organisational context (e.g. government departments, university administrations) as well as within the broader social and political environment of Hong Kong. The documentary evidence contextualised the perspectives and experiences of university managers and non-local students, shedding light on the structural frameworks and discursive environments underpinning their aspirations, decisions and practices related to inward ISM.

Covering both the second and third research questions, open coding and thematic analysis were employed to interpret the interview transcripts with university managers, enabling systematic identification of key patterns and themes. The process involved fragmenting transcripts into discrete segments that captured specific ideas, attitudes or motivations related to attracting and admitting non-local undergraduates (Cohen et al., 2017). This facilitated the development of coherent themes reflecting managers' perspectives, including perceptions of challenges, institutional strategies and the realities that either facilitated or impeded increased student enrolment. For the student interviews, themes emerged around the interaction between systemic and institutional rationales and students' individual choices to study in Hong Kong. Thematic development combined deductive approaches—guided by the study's conceptual framework of multiple forms of capital and existing literature on inward ISM—and inductive methods, allowing new themes to emerge directly from the data. Descriptive statistics were further utilised to quantify the relative influence of individual push and pull factors on students' decisions to study in Hong Kong, contextualised within the broader Bourdieusian framework of capital theory.

All analyses explored how different resources—economic, cultural, social and symbolic—shape and mediate the recruitment, experiences and aspirations of non-local students, as well as systemic policies and institutional strategies. Triangulation across multiple data sources—documents, manager interviews and student questionnaires and interviews—was employed to enhance both validity and depth of understanding (Creswell & Clark, 2017). This comprehensive analytical approach facilitated a nuanced exploration of how these various resource types intersect and influence inward ISM within the higher education landscape of Hong Kong.

FINDINGS

The analysis of the data identified three key themes concerning the attraction and admission of non-local undergraduate students in Hong Kong: firstly, the pursuit of internationalisation and symbolic capital, whereby policymakers and universities framed the presence of particularly non-local, non-Chinese Mainland students as a strategic means to promote Hong Kong's internationalisation efforts and enhance its symbolic standing. While this aspiration was considered achievable by leveraging Hong Kong's role as a ‘super-connector’ with the Chinese Mainland to attract non-Mainland international students to the SAR, the goal of gaining symbolic capital through social networks was not recognised by either higher education institutions or non-local students. Consequently, attracting international students remained a consistent challenge. Secondly, there was a strong emphasis on cultural and (inter)cultural capital, with concerted efforts to foster such attributes primarily for the benefit of local students. However, institutional limitations—particularly in accommodating cultural diversity—impeded the realisation of this aim. Thirdly, the treatment of economic capital revealed that the potential financial gains from recruiting non-local undergraduate students were often minimised, despite universities facing various institutional-level financial challenges—such as limited hostel

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availability and scholarship provisions—in attracting non-local undergraduates. These findings underscore the inconsistencies across different layers in understanding and operationalising inward mobility in Hong Kong.

'Being internationalised' through 'being a super-connector'

An examination of the HKSAR government's policy documents and interviews with university managers indicates that inward non-local students—particularly those from non-Chinese Mainland countries—are regarded as vital for elevating Hong Kong's global profile and enhancing the city-region's symbolic standing within the higher education sector. This symbolic capital is prominently emphasised in the Chief Executive's 2023 and 2024 Policy Addresses, where John Lee Ka-chiu praised inward non-local students for contributing to Hong Kong's vision of becoming 'an international hub for post-secondary education' (Lee, 2024, p. 31). In his 2023 Address, Lee proposed that the city should diversify its student body by attracting more international students, especially from Belt and Road Initiative (BRI) countries (Lee, 2023, p. 67). The government also expressed intentions to increase quotas for scholarships, such as the Belt & Road Scholarship, to expand educational opportunities for students from these regions. The 2024 Policy Address reiterated this strategy, emphasising the goal of admitting 'more overseas students, particularly from ASEAN and other B&R countries', through scholarships and various incentives (Lee, 2024, pp. 31–32). These measures aim to foster a more demographically diverse non-local student population, reduce Mainland dominance and strengthen Hong Kong's position as a global educational hub.

While universities rarely explicitly state 'becoming a higher education hub' as their primary objective in recruiting non-local students, managers universally aspire to cultivate a diverse campus environment. They regard demographic diversity as a crucial component of institutional internationalisation. One staff member from a higher-ranked university—more successful in attracting non-local students—noted:

> We have always been somewhat the preferred university in Hong Kong for Mainland students. Therefore, when it comes to increasing non-local student numbers, our goal is to boost overseas applications and enrolments from international students more than those from the Chinese Mainland. I believe that without a relatively larger or more balanced population of international students, it would be difficult to truly claim to be an international university.

For universities with shorter histories of enrolling non-local students and limited recent growth, the aim of rapidly expanding their international student bodies appeared unrealistic. These institutions often lacked the necessary infrastructure, resources and capacity for global recruitment, which implicitly constrained the number of international students they could admit. This perspective was captured by one manager:

> One reason for the limited growth is the lack of appropriate university infrastructure, including insufficient facilities tailored to international students—such as food options and cultural accommodations. For example, we do not have prayer rooms or other spaces to meet religious needs. Additionally, although application numbers are increasing, we lack enough staff to conduct interviews, even when applicants are qualified. Another unproven but perceived factor contributing to low international student numbers is feedback from parents and students during webinar sharing sessions. Some reported that certain professors, who are expected to teach in English, do not use English in the classroom. This

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> discourages international students and creates challenges for their integration, leading some to be deterred from applying to the university.

Simultaneously, Hong Kong's role as 'a super-connector for the Mainland' is viewed as advantageous for attracting non-local international students, particularly from ASEAN and BRI countries. This transformation of social capital into symbolic capital was explicitly articulated by policymakers on various occasions. For example, after organising a 2-day Global University Presidents and Leaders Summit, LegCo member Professor Priscilla Leung Mei-fun stated on TVB's Straight Talk (Chan, 2024):

> We are the super-connectors of top talents. We need to tell the good story of Hong Kong… I told them we can connect them to the biggest market, which is China. They are so inspired. We want to see talents from all over the world come to Hong Kong and bring their unique abilities. Hong Kong will truly become a very internationalised city for China and the world.

At the meso- and micro levels, however, university managers and student participants expressed ambivalence regarding the role of connection in their recruitment and decision-making processes. From their perspective, links with the Mainland appeared more relevant to the recruitment of Mainland students than to international students more generally. This view was echoed by one staff member, who explicitly stated, 'those are two things'. Data from the push-pull questionnaire further supported this: among the 36 international respondents—34 of whom were from BRI countries—only 30.6% considered engagement with the BRI and the links between Hong Kong/China and their home countries as the most significant factor influencing their decision to study in Hong Kong. Interview insights corroborated this finding.

The accumulation of (inter)cultural capital for the benefit of local students

Increasing inbound non-local student enrolment is widely regarded as essential for fostering cross-cultural awareness in Hong Kong. As the EDB advised the Legislative Council (LegCo) in 2022:

> [O]utstanding non-local students who come to Hong Kong for study will help create a more international and diverse campus environment at our higher education institutions, promote academic and cultural exchanges, and deepen non-local talents' understanding of and affection for our country and Hong Kong.
> (Government of the HKSAR, 2022)

These discourses explicitly emphasise one of the core objectives of attracting more non-local students: to cultivate individuals with knowledge of and goodwill towards Hong Kong and China as a whole. This aligns with the overarching goal for inward ISM articulated by China's Ministry of Education, which seeks to convert accumulated (cross-)cultural capital into symbolic capital—thereby enhancing Hong Kong's international influence (Pan, 2021).

However, university managers seldom acknowledged this process of conversion. Instead, they predominantly framed the cultural benefits of inbound non-local students as opportunities to diversify campus environments for the benefit of domestic students. For example, when asked about the motivations behind recruiting non-local students, one participating manager explained:

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> The primary reason is our desire to internationalise the campus through the recruitment of non-local students. This initiative operates on multiple levels. The most obvious is the presence of students from diverse regions, with different backgrounds and appearances. Such diversity benefits our local students by exposing them to various cultures and perspectives. For instance, when they later enter the workforce or live in more international environments, they will feel more comfortable and confident in multicultural settings.

While institutional stakeholders involved in non-local student recruitment explicitly emphasised this cultural rationale in their discourse, it was much less evident among the students themselves. Almost no student informants cited cultural values as a primary motivation for choosing Hong Kong. Instead, their experiences revealed a disconnect between expectations—such as assuming 'people speak English' (female, 25, Burmese, Year 5, English Language and English Education)—and reality, where 'people speak Cantonese and Mandarin' (female, 21, Tanzanian, Year 2, STEM). Many students noted that they were initially taken aback by these linguistic differences and subsequently turned to co-national peers for practical support, such as navigating 'what I need to do after I came here' (male, 19, Kazakh, Year 2, STEM).

These experiences also raised questions about how well Hong Kong university campuses accommodate the diverse backgrounds of non-local students—a point highlighted by a manager from a relatively more 'internationalised' institution:

> Another major challenge for the entire campus and the education system as a whole is the level of understanding and competence in intercultural communication among faculty and administrative staff. In Hong Kong, we may not explicitly focus on cross-cultural competency; instead, we tend to emphasise cross-border competency—specifically, interactions between Hong Kong residents and those from the Mainland. I believe both faculty and administrative staff could improve and do more in this area. That said, I also see this challenge as an opportunity. Rather than viewing intercultural communication purely as a barrier, we should leverage the dynamic nature of our multicultural learning environment to maximise its benefits. In my view, we have not yet done enough to develop and support this aspect, and there is significant potential for growth.

Within this context, while discourses highlighting the cross-cultural value of students' transnational mobility were widespread in both external and internal university communications, institutions appeared to underutilise the cultural advantages that non-local students could offer.

'Increasing tuition revenue is not a policy objective'

Hosting non-local undergraduate students was regarded as being of lesser importance in generating economic capital for local universities. In the EDB's response to oral questions from LegCo members on 20 November 2024—concerning the expanded admission quota for non-local students—the Secretary for Education, Dr. Choi Yuk-lin, explicitly stated: 'Increasing the income from tuition fees is not the policy objective' (Government of the HKSAR, 2024). Nonetheless, financial support measures—such as scholarships—were viewed by both the HKSAR government and university managers as the most effective strategies (alongside efforts to enhance higher education competitiveness) for attracting non-Mainland international students. This emphasis on financial incentives was also reflected in

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student interviews. For example, one participant (female, 22, Kazakhstani, Year 3, English Language and English Education) explained:

> My family doesn't have much money to pay for my education. So, the biggest criterion for my choice was the full scholarship that would cover not just tuition fees but also my airfare and living expenses. I applied to the US, Turkey, Russia, Kazakhstan, Hungary, South Korea, Hong Kong, and the Czech Republic. Hong Kong was not my first priority. However, the university offered me the largest scholarship compared to the other options, and that's why I am here.

By contrast, most of the Mainland students (105 out of 133) relied on parental support for their studies in Hong Kong and expressed a desire for more scholarship opportunities during the interviews. Nevertheless, the annual quota for the HKSAR government's Belt & Road Scholarship increased gradually—from 80 recipients in 2019 to 100 in 2020, before reaching 150 beneficiaries per academic year in 2023. As a result, some institutions relied on their own funds to provide additional incentives, such as entrance scholarships.

While university managers publicly maintained that inbound non-local students were not primarily viewed as a financial resource, they also reflected on the financial challenges faced by their institutions. One staff member remarked:

> In fact, over the past five years, I've observed an increase in the number of scholarships—partly because we are expanding our outreach to more developing countries, where international students often cannot fully afford the tuition fees we charge. This partly explains why we need to offer more scholarships to attract these students. We actually allocate a substantial amount of funding for this, as many of the scholarships cover the entire four-year undergraduate programme.

Furthermore, higher education institutions in Hong Kong faced a common challenge in securing sufficient hostel accommodation for both non-local and local students. About 50.89% of questionnaire respondents considered the availability of student accommodation an important factor when choosing to study in Hong Kong. Many expressed dissatisfaction during interviews regarding the shortage of student hostels and the complex procedures students must navigate to accumulate points in order to continue residing in their accommodation after the first academic year. One staff informant explained:

> What the Hong Kong government talks about is somewhat abstract, and there are difficulties in translating its plans into practice. Has the government alleviated some of these issues for us? The resource we need is simply enough dormitories. Of course, land in Hong Kong is a problem, as are local student hostels. But as an international education hub, this issue must be addressed. If non-local students live outside campus, they have fewer opportunities to interact with other students.

In addition, our analysis revealed that the HKSAR government explicitly recognises inward mobility flows as a means to address Hong Kong's shrinking skilled labour force. For instance, the UGC (2024) and the Legislative Council's Subcommittee on Promoting the Development of Hong Kong into an International Education Hub (2025) explicitly stated: ‘Attracting and retaining non-local talents to live and work in Hong Kong will enhance the quality of our population and the overall competitiveness of Hong Kong in the long term’ (UGC, 2024, p. 1). This acknowledgement aligns with the introduction of welcoming visa and

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immigration policies—such as the IANG scheme. Approximately 124 out of the 169 student participants (73.37%) considered career opportunities in Hong Kong a significant factor in their study choices. One student expressed a desire to 'stay in Hong Kong because I want to work as a teacher for several years' (male, 19, Kyrgyzstani, Year 1, STEM), while another aimed to 'achieve permanent residence in Hong Kong' (male, 23, Rwandan, Year 4, STEM).

Conversely, university managers generally expressed scepticism regarding the prospects of non-local students securing employment in Hong Kong. One staff informant emphasised that immigration policies were not regarded as a primary motivation for recruiting international students, noting:

> The job market is very pragmatic. I consider employment prospects from the employers' perspective. I've encountered non-local international students who have told me directly that, because they are non-local and do not speak Cantonese, they are denied certain opportunities—not only for paid employment but even for internships. I've also heard similar concerns from Mainland students with limited Cantonese proficiency.

DISCUSSIONS AND CONCLUSION

This study, grounded in a cross-level analysis of macro, meso and micro dynamics, reveals how Hong Kong's pursuit of non-local undergraduate recruitment is shaped by interconnected yet often misaligned capital-driven logics.

At the macro level, the HKSAR government's primary motivation centres on accruing symbolic capital—aimed at enhancing Hong Kong's status as a 'global education hub' and projecting soft power—particularly emphasising its role as a 'super-connector' to the Chinese Mainland (Pan, 2021). Unlike Western contexts where ISM is frequently associated with neoliberal imperatives of economic capital accumulation (e.g. revenue generation) or talent retention for national development (Altbach & Knight, 2007; de Wit et al., 2015), Hong Kong's policy discourse tends to downplay commercialisation. Instead, it increasingly explicitly highlights immigration pathways, notably through the IANG visa scheme, aimed at retaining graduates (Baas, 2019). However, this is not prominently featured within the branding strategies of 'Study in Hong Kong'. The ambiguity surrounding economic or human capital objectives may also reflect sensitivities to local protectionist narratives, where non-local students are sometimes framed as competitors for limited resources (Stein & De Andreotti, 2016). This tension becomes more pronounced given Hong Kong's projected fiscal deficit of HK$100 billion (approximately US$12.8 billion) for 2024–25, alongside austerity measures (Government of the HKSAR, 2025). As a result, higher education institutions may increasingly rely on non-local tuition fees, thereby intensifying unspoken economic imperatives that conflict with the official emphasis on symbolic capital (Sharma, 2025).

At the meso level, universities respond to these macro policy currents with their own strategies centred on capital accumulation, yet misalignments persist. Institutional leaders recognise non-local students as sources of symbolic capital—enhancing global rankings—and as providers of cultural capital—enriching campus diversity for local students (Vuong et al., 2021). Nonetheless, operational practices reveal gaps: efforts to foster intercultural competence remain underdeveloped, leaving institutions ill-equipped to meet the needs of inwardly mobile students (Buckner & Stein, 2020). Furthermore, while universities acknowledge the economic value of non-local tuition, they tend to downplay this in favour of aligning with the government's symbolic narratives—though funding constraints may push them towards greater financial dependence on such students. These inconsistencies are compounded by fragmented policy signals from bodies such as the UGC and the EDB,

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which interpret 'internationalisation' through divergent lenses, hindering the development of cohesive institutional strategies.

At the micro level, non-local students' motivations reflect their own calculations of capital, which often diverge from macro and meso priorities. While policymakers and institutions emphasise Hong Kong's symbolic capital (e.g. global prestige) and cultural capital (e.g. East–West exposure), students tend to prioritise practical forms such as economic returns (perceived career opportunities), social capital (transnational networks) and tangible safety assurances—factors underemphasised in official 'Study in Hong Kong' branding. This disconnect highlights how student agency reshapes the meanings of capital: their choices are driven less by Hong Kong's role as a 'hub' and more by pragmatic assessments of how the city's education system can enhance their individual capital portfolios.

The cross-level tensions identified above are inherently rooted in the divergent rationales and intended outcomes of key stakeholders within Hong Kong's ISM ecosystem. These conflicting objectives across different actor groups are a defining feature of marketised higher education, as each party pursues interests shaped by their positional power, institutional mandates and individual aspirations. At the macro level, actors such as the HKSAR government, the UGC and the EDB primarily base their rationales on city-region-building and geopolitical imperatives. As Oleksiyenko et al. (2021) observe, governments in East Asian contexts often frame internationalisation as a means of accumulating symbolic capital and enhancing regional influence, rather than focusing purely on economic benefits. This aligns with Hong Kong's discourse of establishing itself as a 'global education hub'. Meso-level actors, namely universities, operate within this ambiguous policy environment and must balance multiple, often competing rationales. Institutional leaders are motivated by both symbolic capital—such as global rankings and prestige—and economic survival. These logics can sometimes clash, creating tensions within institutional strategies (Vuong et al., 2021). At the micro level, non-local students bring forward individualised rationales rooted in human capital theory and pragmatic life-course planning. Unlike policymakers and institutions, these students prioritise outcomes that directly enhance their employability, social networks and personal safety. This reflects a broader trend in global student mobility, where learners increasingly act as 'strategic agents' calculating the returns in their investments in education (Gao et al., 2025). This misalignment with institutional and policy priorities mirrors findings from Yang's (2018) research on Indian students in China, where students' motivations centred on practical career gains, often diverging from institutional narratives of income generation and symbolic prestige.

In conclusion, cross-level tensions are evident in three key areas: (1) policy-institution misalignment—government downplaying of economic capital conflicts with institutional financial pressures; (2) institution-student misalignment—universities' focus on cultural capital for local students overlooks the needs of non-local students; and (3) symbolic-practical misalignment—official emphasis on Hong Kong's 'super-connector' status fails to resonate with students' priorities regarding career prospects. These gaps explain Hong Kong's challenges in attracting students beyond the Greater China region and the absence of a coherent strategy for sustainable ISM (Lee, 2024).

For policymakers, this cross-level analysis underscores the necessity of reconciling symbolic aspirations with pragmatic support measures: aligning the promotion of the IANG visa scheme with active recruitment strategies, clarifying funding frameworks to reduce institutional ambiguity and integrating student priorities—such as safety—into branding efforts. For universities, a better alignment between cultural capital initiatives (e.g. intercultural programmes) and student needs, combined with targeted career services, could enhance their competitiveness. Crucially, fostering a more positive public perception of non-local students as collaborators and contributors rather than competitors is vital to positioning Hong Kong as a genuinely inclusive educational hub (Oleksiyenko et al., 2021).

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By extending Bourdieu's framework across macro, meso and micro levels, this study moves beyond siloed perspectives to reveal how capital dynamics are co-constructed through interaction. It demonstrates that ISM is not merely a top-down process of capital accumulation but a relational phenomenon, where student agency, institutional strategies and policy discourses mutually shape the meanings and values of economic, cultural, social and symbolic capital. This integrated perspective offers new insights into the complexities of higher education internationalisation within multipolar contexts—particularly regions navigating geopolitical and economic pressures (Gao et al., 2024; Marginson, 2020).

Longitudinal research tracking policy shifts, institutional adaptations and student mobility patterns would illuminate the evolving nature of these capital dynamics. Further investigation could also explore how Hong Kong's ISM strategies interact with the Chinese Mainland's broader initiatives, such as the BRI, and how regional hubs are reshaping global hierarchies of capital.

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CONFLICT OF INTEREST STATEMENT

There are no conflicts of interest to be reported.

DATA AVAILABILITY STATEMENT

The data that support the findings of this study are available on request from the corresponding author. The data are not publicly available due to privacy or ethical restrictions.

ETHICS STATEMENT

All participants are adults and gave informed consent before taking part.

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